

Wednesday, 29 July 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON Clear 34° 21°	BIRMINGHAM Overcast 28° 19°	MANCHESTER Light drizzle 23° 17°	GLASGOW Rain 17° 14°
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01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

- 1

Get ready to feel the heat again, as a fourth heatwave of the year is now underway for parts of the UK.

Temperatures are expected to climb into the mid-30s Celsius later this week. It's certainly been a summer of extremes across the country.

WEATHER · UK
- 2

The government is proposing that schools in England offer technical subjects to pupils from as young as 14.

The idea is to link these courses, like AI and manufacturing, directly to local job opportunities. It's all about preparing young people for the future workforce.

EDUCATION · UK
- 3

There's an extraordinary story emerging from the French Navy, who reportedly carried out a 'shooting drill' mid-interview.

Shadow Home Secretary Chris Philp was giving an interview when the vessel apparently fired 17 shots. Quite the unexpected backdrop for a political discussion!

DEFENCE · UK
- 4

Police are investigating after a Virgin jet engineer tragically died following an accident at Heathrow Airport.

Georgie Buxton sustained fatal injuries while working on a jet. Our thoughts are with her family and colleagues at this difficult time.

ACCIDENT · UK
- 5

Hundreds of thousands of women across England have now received the morning-after pill via a new free pharmacy service.

The scheme, which launched last October, makes the medication available free-of-charge at high street pharmacies. It aims to improve access to essential healthcare.

HEALTH · UK

What's coming up

1 **Big news for Strictly Come Dancing fans: House of the Dragon star Bethany Antonia has joined the line-up!**

She plays Lady Baela Targaryen in the HBO prequel and is the ninth celebrity confirmed for the upcoming series. Get ready to see her on the dancefloor!

ON AIR – Who would you love to see join the Strictly line-up this year?

TV · COMING UP

2 **Comedian Joe Lycett is venturing into the art world with his first major solo exhibition, opening this Wednesday in Birmingham.**

Expect something unique, as he's reportedly featuring a giant pink mammoth and even Ceefax in his show. Sounds like classic Joe Lycett!

ON AIR – What's the most unusual art exhibition you've ever been to?

ART · COMING UP

3 **The Booker Prize longlist has been revealed, featuring 13 'dynamite' novels vying for this year's prestigious award.**

Big names like Elizabeth Strout, Douglas Stuart, and Marlon James are among those recognised. It's always exciting to see which books make the cut!

ON AIR – Have you read any of the longlisted books, or do you have a favourite author you hope wins?

BOOKS · COMING UP

4 **Horror maestro Mike Flanagan is joining Henry Cavill on the highly anticipated Warhammer adaptations.**

The director is set to work on scripts based on the popular tabletop hobby. Fans of the fantasy universe will be thrilled with this news!

ON AIR – Are you a fan of the Warhammer universe, and what are your hopes for these adaptations?

FILM · COMING UP

5 **Womad founder Peter Gabriel says it's getting tougher for music festivals to survive in the UK.**

The Genesis frontman admitted that putting on the Wiltshire festival is always a 'gamble'. It's a tough climate for live music events.

ON AIR – What's your favourite music festival, and why do you think it's so important to support them?

MUSIC · COMING UP

On the schedule

- 1 **Xabi Alonso's first match as Chelsea manager was quite the opener, with the story defined by four strikers.**
From a hat-trick hero to one who might be leaving, it was certainly an eventful start. Fans will be eager to see how the team develops under his leadership.

ON AIR – What are your early impressions of Xabi Alonso at Chelsea, and what do you expect from them this season?

FOOTBALL · UK

- 2 **There's a significant change coming to how VAR is used in football, with referee chiefs saying it should only be for 'blatantly incorrect' decisions.**
European refereeing officials want VAR to intervene only on clear missed incidents. It's hoped this will streamline the game and reduce controversy.

ON AIR – Do you think limiting VAR to 'blatantly incorrect' decisions will improve the game, or do you prefer more intervention?

FOOTBALL · UK

- 3 **Celtic have broken their transfer record to sign Danish striker Kasper Høgh from Bodo/Glimt on a four-year contract.**
The club describes him as 'a really good match' for the team. Fans will be excited to see their new record signing in action.

ON AIR – Do you think Kasper Høgh will be a good fit for Celtic, and how important are big signings for a club?

FOOTBALL · UK

- 4 **Gymnast Ruby Evans has delivered Wales' first gold medal at the Glasgow Commonwealth Games with a stunning victory in the floor final.**
What an incredible achievement for Ruby and for Wales! It's always inspiring to see our athletes shine on the big stage.

ON AIR – Which Commonwealth Games event are you most enjoying watching this week?

GYMNASTICS · UK

- 5 **Manchester City midfielder Rodri is set to be sidelined for a 'short period' after undergoing back surgery on Monday.**
It's a blow for City, but hopefully, he'll be back on the pitch soon. We wish him a speedy recovery.

ON AIR – How big a miss will Rodri be for Manchester City in the coming weeks?

FOOTBALL · UK

Quick hits

- 1 The surprising power of a good 'earworm' is being explored by researchers.**
Scientists suggest that catchy tunes stuck in our heads might actually boost memory and concentration for some tasks. It seems our brains are quite good at multitasking, even with a song playing on repeat!
- 2 A new trend is seeing people create 'miniature landscapes' in plant pots.**
Think tiny benches, little pathways, and even miniature ponds, all nestled amongst succulents or small ferns. It's a delightful way to bring a touch of the outdoors indoors on a small scale.
- 3 The simple pleasure of 'window shopping' is being rediscovered as a mindful activity.**
Psychologists note that observing shop displays without the pressure to buy can be a relaxing way to engage with creativity and trends, rather than just focusing on consumption.
- 4 Experts are suggesting that collecting 'interesting local facts' can deepen our connection to our communities.**
Learning about the history of a local landmark or a quirky detail about a street can make everyday walks much more engaging and personal.
- 5 The satisfying art of 'skip-watching' (observing what people put in skips) is gaining a cult following.**
It's a surprisingly popular pastime for some, offering a glimpse into the changing lives of neighbours and sometimes even a chance to spot a hidden treasure!
- 6 A study found that 'wearing mismatched socks' can subtly boost creativity and individuality.**
It's thought that the small act of breaking a convention can encourage a more playful and open mindset throughout the day. So, feel free to mix and match!
- 7 The delightful art of 'doodling while on the phone' is being recognised for its unexpected benefits.**
Research suggests that these casual sketches can actually help improve recall of information discussed during a conversation, keeping your mind engaged without distracting from the main topic.

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q Our survey said that over 65% of us admit to secretly 'doing' what when we're trying to find something in a cluttered drawer?

ANSWER: TAKING EVERYTHING OUT AND THEN PUTTING IT ALL BACK IN A SLIGHTLY DIFFERENT ORDER, HOPING IT MAGICALLY APPEARS!

Q Our survey said that over 70% of us admit to having a particular 'odd habit' they absolutely have to do before settling down to watch their favourite TV show. What is it?

ANSWER: ADJUSTING ALL THE CUSHIONS ON THE SOFA TO 'JUST THE RIGHT' LEVEL OF SQUISHINESS!

TALK TOPIC

- You know how sometimes a particular 'smell' instantly takes you back to a specific memory or a moment in time?

What's that one scent that, for you, is like a time machine in your nose? Is it freshly cut grass, baking bread, or perhaps a particular perfume?

- We all have those 'little everyday objects' that we can't quite bring ourselves to throw away, even if they're a bit worn or broken, don't we?

What's that one item in your home that holds surprisingly significant sentimental value, even if it looks like absolute junk to everyone else?

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **Animals.** Did you know that a group of owls is actually called a 'parliament'?

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** It's true that butterflies taste with their antennae, allowing them to sense nectar from a distance.

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£25 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£3.8 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- Honey never spoils; archaeologists have found pots of honey in ancient Egyptian tombs that are over 3,000 years old and still edible.
- The shortest war in history was between Britain and Zanzibar on August 27, 1896; it lasted only 38 minutes.
- A 'bibliosmia' is the pleasure of smelling old books.
- It is impossible for most people to lick their own elbow.
- The original name for the butterfly was 'flutterby'.
- The tiny pocket on jeans was originally designed for pocket watches.
- The world's largest officially named ocean is the Pacific Ocean.
- The human heart creates enough pressure to squirt blood 30 feet.

On this day

Day 210 of the year, 155 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Lazarus of Bethany; Christian feast day: Lupus of Troyes; Christian feast day: Martha of Bethany (Catholic, Anglican, and Lutheran Church); Christian feast day: Mary of Bethany. Star sign Leo, birthstone Ruby.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1958 — Simon Nye, English screenwriter and producer
- 1963 — Jim Beglin, Irish footballer and sportscaster
- 1966 — Sally Gunnell, English hurdler and sportscaster
- 1923 — Gordon Mitchell, American bodybuilder and actor (died 2003)
- 1953 — Patti Scialfa, American musician
- 1946 — Diane Keen, English actress
- 1969 — Timothy Omundson, American actor
- 1933 — Lou Albano, Italian-American wrestler, manager, and actor (died 2009)

THE DAY TODAY

- 1976 — In New York City, David Berkowitz (a.k.a. the "Son of Sam") kills one person and seriously wounds another in the first of a series of attacks.
- 2015 — The first piece of suspected debris from Malaysia Airlines Flight 370 is discovered on Réunion Island.
- 2021 — The International Space Station temporarily spins out of control, moving the ISS 45 degrees out of attitude, following an engine malfunction of Russian module Nauka.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 2010 — An overloaded passenger ferry capsizes on the Kasai River in Bandundu Province, Democratic Republic of the Congo, resulting in at least 80 deaths.
- 1980 — Iran adopts a new "holy" flag after the Islamic Revolution.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 1965 — Vietnam War: The first 4,000 101st Airborne Division paratroopers arrive in Vietnam, landing at Cam Ranh Bay.
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1950 — Korean War: After four days, the No Gun Ri Massacre ends when the US Army 7th Cavalry Regiment is withdrawn.

- 1981 — After impeachment on June 21, Abolhassan Banisadr flees with Massoud Rajavi to Paris, in an Iranian Air Force Boeing 707, piloted by Colonel Behzad Moezzi, to form the National Council of Resistance of Iran.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 211 of the year, 154 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Abdon and Sennen; Christian feast day: Blessed Edward Powell, Richard Fetherston and Thomas Abel; Christian feast day: Hatebrand; Christian feast day: María Natividad Venegas de la Torre. Star sign Leo, birthstone Ruby.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1944 — Frances de la Tour, English actress
- 1965 — Tim Munton, English cricketer
- 1970 — Christopher Nolan, English-American director, producer, and screenwriter
- 1980 — Justin Rose, South African-English golfer
- 1963 — Lisa Kudrow, American actress and producer
- 1939 — Peter Bogdanovich, American actor, director, producer, and screenwriter (died 2022)
- 1960 — Richard Linklater, American director and screenwriter
- 1971 — Christine Taylor, American actress

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 1978 — The 730: Okinawa Prefecture changes its traffic on the right-hand side of the road to the left-hand side.
- 1980 — Vanuatu gains independence.
- 2003 — In Mexico, the last 'old style' Volkswagen Beetle rolls off the assembly line.

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 2012 — A power grid failure in Delhi leaves more than 300 million people without power in northern India.
- 1965 — U.S. president Lyndon B. Johnson signs the Social Security Act of 1965 into law, establishing Medicare and Medicaid.

Coming to cinemas

JULY 2026

FRI 31 Spider-Man: Brand New Day

AUGUST 2026

FRI 7 Once Upon a Time in a Cinema

FRI 14 Flowervale Street; PAW Patrol 3: The Dino Movie

FRI 21 Mutiny; The Bride!

FRI 28 Crime 101; Outcome

SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 4 Conjuring: Last Rites

FRI 11 Resident Evil reboot

FRI 18 The Black Phone 2

FRI 25 Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)

OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 16 Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller

FRI 23 Frankenstein (del Toro)

On the sporting calendar

JULY 2026

23 JUL — 2 AUG Commonwealth Games, Glasgow

AUGUST 2026

W/C 10 Hundred & T20 Blast climax (Cricket)

SAT 15 Premier League season begins (2026/27)

22–23 Belgian Grand Prix (F1)